DEMOCRATIC EROSION OBSERVATORY

Methodology

How the index scores democratic erosion, and the rules that keep scores comparable

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Purpose

The Democratic Erosion Observatory scores six indicators of democratic health on a 0 to 4 scale, by country, each quarter. Higher scores mean more erosion. The composite is the mean of the six indicator scores (indicator weights are currently equal; the framework allows reweighting later). Scores are forward-looking and condition-based, so they may lead benchmark indices such as V-Dem and Freedom House rather than simply tracking them.

THE SIX INDICATORS

- Executive Constraint
- Judicial Independence
- Electoral Integrity
- Press & Media Freedom
- Civil Society Space
- Chilling Effect and Self-Censorship

Each indicator carries its own definition, benchmark source, and scoring guide. The precise per-level criteria live in a rubric with one cell per indicator and score level (30 cells in total). Each score entry is tied to the exact rubric cell that justifies its number.

The severity ladder

The same five-rung logic (the pressure yardstick) applies across every indicator. Per-indicator wording sits in the rubric; the generic meaning of each rung is:

- **0 Baseline:** the democratic function operates as intended.
- **1 Rhetorical / Isolated Pressure:** hostile rhetoric or isolated friction; checks and norms hold.
- **2 Tools Deployed:** institutional or legal tools are used against the function, repeatedly and deliberately, but not yet decisively.
- **3 Serious:** structural degradation; major capture, purging, or systematic suppression is in progress.
- **4 Effectively Defeated:** the function is effectively defeated and the check no longer operates.

Governing rules

DE-CONFLICTION

When a single event implicates more than one indicator, the enacted act is scored once, under its home indicator, and cross-referenced (not re-scored) elsewhere. For example, executive control of the courts is de-conflicted to Executive Constraint, while Judicial Independence scores the courts' own loss of independence. This stops one event from inflating several indicators at once.

QUIESCENCE CHECK

Fear-induced quiet is not improvement. Before lowering a score because visible incidents declined, check whether the drop reflects genuine recovery or suppression-driven silence. The Chilling Effect and Self-Censorship indicator exists precisely so that event-count scoring does not misread fear-induced quiet as a return to health.

SATURATION CHECK

The inverse of the quiescence check. Once acts under an indicator become too numerous to enumerate, the score reflects the state of the function, not the count of incidents. Two or three anchor acts document the structural condition (the mechanism by which the check has stopped operating), and a saturation note records that the score reflects a saturated field rather than any single act. Volume alone does not lift a score above the rung its structural criteria justify: a flood of incidents supports Serious (3), but the move to Effectively Defeated (4) still requires showing that the check structurally no longer operates. This keeps event volume from inflating a score the same way the quiescence check keeps event scarcity from deflating one, and it preserves resolution beneath the 4.0 ceiling so the index can still register movement at the top of the ladder.

Confidence, direction, and sourcing

Confidence. Each entry carries a confidence rating reflecting the strength and convergence of the evidence: **High** (multiple independent, reliable sources converge), **Medium** (credible evidence with some gaps or limited corroboration), or **Low** (suggestive but thin or contested evidence).

Direction vs last. Quarter-over-quarter movement of the indicator, read independently of the absolute score: Worsened, Held, Improved, or New (scored for the first time).

Sourcing standard. Every entry is tied to records in a source library, where each source carries a type, publisher, reliability rating, and key takeaway. Primary documents such as court rulings, official clearances, and statutes are preferred as anchors; secondary reporting supports and contextualizes.

Comparative anchoring. Where useful, an entry names an international or historical precedent (for example, Hungary's KESMA media consolidation in 2018, or the contrast between Russia's barred opposition and Turkey's 2024 local-election result). This calibrates scores against established cases rather than scoring in isolation.

Current scores: Q2 2026

Q2 2026 is the most recent complete scoring cycle. Five of the eight countries in the comparative frame have been scored; India, Serbia, and Slovakia are set up but not yet scored. Russia is included as a closed-autocracy ceiling case anchoring the top of the scale.

COUNTRY	ELECTORAL	JUDICIAL	EXECUTIVE	CIVIL SOCIETY	PRESS	CHILLING	COMPOSITE	TREND
Poland	1	2	1	1	1	1	**1.17**	Stable
United States	2	2	2	2	3	3	**2.33**	Eroding
Hungary	2	3	2	3	3	1	**2.33**	Improving
Turkey	3	3	3	3	3	3	**3.00**	Sharply eroding
Russia	4	4	4	4	4	4	**4.00**	Eroding

Composite is the unweighted mean of the six indicator scores. Trend reflects direction from the prior cycle; Poland, Turkey, and Russia were scored for the first time in Q2 2026, so their trend reflects the analyst's reading of current conditions rather than a measured quarter-over-quarter change. Scoring is paused following the Q2 2026 cycle.